

first woman in the Gowda household to be a part of the 224-member Karnataka Assembly last year.

Yeddyurappa has done his own bit of dynastic politics. In April 2009, his 36-year-old son B.Y. Raghavendra defeated serial party-hopper and former chief minister Sarekoppa Bangarappa from Shimoga. The only tall Vokkaliga leader in the Congress to match Gowda is S.M. Krishna who, as India's external affairs minister, hardly has the time to be involved in Karnataka's affairs.

them to boot into the global world of knowledge-based superpower club but won't log them into the majority voters' hearts. And after helping the BJP win 117 seats in the 224-member Assembly, Yeddyurappa does not want to lose control. Especially after the tough year that 2009 was for him: the JD(S), his key political enemy, acquired extra strength, picking three additional seats in the Vokkaliga stronghold of south Karnataka.

While the BJP has control in the coastal and north Karnataka belts, it

bought his plea for a mandate for stability. Both claim to be working for the interest of farmers. "I am more concerned about the plight of farmers than anybody else. I am also a *mannina maga*, son of the soil. We are pro-farmer," says Yeddyurappa. Not one to let Yeddyurappa take credit for being the farmers' messiah, Gowda hit back, saying, "Yeddyurappa should first understand the plight of farmers. We are not against development but don't take the farmers for a ride or cause them pain."



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DEVE GOWDA, JD(S) Supreme

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Gowda's expletive-laced diatribe was provoked by what he claims were attacks on farmers whose lands have been acquired for the Rs 3,200 crore, 20,000-odd acre private sector Bangalore-Mysore Infrastructure Corridor project promoted by entrepreneur Ashok Kheny, an open Gowda baiter and a Lingayat to boot. Kheny has also been waging a legal battle to complete the 111-km tolled expressway that involves five townships and infrastructure development spanning roughly 13,000 acres.

Both Gowda and Yeddyurappa also know that it may help both of

has no clue how to storm the Vokkaliga bastions of south Karnataka where Gowda holds sway. Even with 20 BJP legislators in the Bangalore region—and two cabinet ministers in charge of the district—the party candidates lost in the Christmas 2009 Legislative Council elections while the JD(S) gained.

When the JD(S) pulled the plug in 2007, displaying Machiavellian machinations in a coalition-controlled political setup, Yeddyurappa rode back to power after a gruelling five-month, 14,500-km “dharma yuddha” across the state where the crowds

While no psephologist can accurately predict crowd behaviour when it comes to the hustings, both Gowda and Yeddyurappa are willing to take a gamble to don the role of regional satraps. The scheduled Assembly elections may be two years away in Karnataka, but for the two men who are fighting each other for control over turf, opportunities are just moments away.

While Gowda has put his autobiography on hold, Yeddyurappa may have to watch out for attacks from within his own party while playing the CEO of the soil. ■

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